

A Note on the Characterization of EDSL in *Anamnesis: An Open-Source Platform for Large-Scale Backstory-Conditioned Survey Simulation*

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Abstract

Yu et al. characterize Expected Parrot’s EDSL as restricting persona conditioning to short attribute profiles. This note clarifies that the claim describes a default presentation rather than a limitation of EDSL. EDSL agents can carry long narrative backstories, render them through customizable Jinja2 persona templates, and retain earlier questions and answers through survey memory. EDSL can therefore express the backstory conditioning and sequential context accumulation central to the Anthology procedure. Anamnesis has useful distinctive contributions, particularly its curated persona pool, probabilistic demographic inference and matching, and graphical workflow, but rich narrative conditioning is not a capability absent from EDSL.

1 The claim

In their related-work comparison, Yu et al. write that EDSL “provides a Python domain-specific language for constructing AI agents with trait dictionaries and administering surveys across multiple LLMs, but its persona conditioning reduces to the short-attribute prompting baseline that Anthology was designed to supersede” [1]. This characterization is not accurate as a statement about EDSL’s capabilities.

EDSL does provide a convenient dictionary of agent traits. Its default presentation may serialize those traits compactly, which can resemble the short demographic profiles used by some persona-prompting baselines. The default serialization, however, is not the boundary of the abstraction.

2 Narrative backstories in EDSL

An EDSL agent has a customizable `traits_presentation_template`. This is a Jinja2 template that can reference individual traits, the complete trait dictionary, and an optional codebook [2]. Consequently, a trait can contain a multi-paragraph life history and the template can place that history directly into the model prompt. For example:

```
from edsl import Agent

agent = Agent(
    traits={
        "backstory": """
        Maria grew up in ...
```

```

        [a multi-paragraph account of formative experiences,
        relationships, values, circumstances, and worldview]
        """
    },
    traits_presentation_template="""
    Adopt the perspective of the person described below.

    {{ backstory }}
    """,
)

```

There is therefore no structural distinction between an “attribute” holding a short value such as an age and one holding a rich narrative. More precisely, the presentation template is evaluated as Jinja2 and trait values are inserted into it; the trait values need not themselves be templates. The practical limits on backstory length are the selected model’s context window, inference cost, and experimental design—not an EDSL restriction to short profiles.

The agent’s general instruction is customizable as well, providing another way to specify how the model should inhabit or reason from the supplied life history.

3 Sequential survey context

Yu et al. describe Anamnesis’s Anthology answering mode as prepending a backstory and then accumulating prior question–answer pairs so that later answers remain consistent [1]. EDSL supports this pattern through survey memory. A researcher can expose every earlier answer to each later question:

```

survey = Survey(questions).set_full_memory_mode()
results = survey.by(agent).by(model).run()

```

Alternatively, targeted memory can specify exactly which earlier answers are included for a given question. Thus EDSL supports both full sequential context accumulation and more controlled experimental variants.

4 A more precise comparison

This correction does not diminish the substantive contributions of Anamnesis. The system described by Yu et al. combines several features into an accessible application, including a pool of approximately 35,000 pre-generated backstories, probabilistic demographic annotations, demographic selection and matching procedures, and a graphical survey workflow [1]. Those are meaningful product and methodological distinctions.

The comparison would be more accurate if it separated the *persona representation* from the *surrounding workflow*. For example:

EDSL defaults to dictionary-style trait presentation, but supports arbitrary narrative backstories through long-form traits and customizable Jinja2 persona templates, as well as sequential question–answer memory. Unlike Anamnesis, EDSL does not provide the same pre-indexed backstory pool and probabilistic demographic-matching workflow out of the box.

The paper also suggests that EDSL requires explicit code-based specification of scenarios, models, tools, policies, and evaluation hooks. These are optional compositional capabilities rather than requirements for a basic survey. EDSL also provides a command-line interface for constructing agents and surveys without writing Python. Finally, EDSL itself is open-source software distributed under the MIT License [2]; it should be distinguished from any separate hosted services offered by Expected Parrot.

5 Conclusion

EDSL can implement Anthology-style narrative conditioning without a change to its agent abstraction: the backstory can be stored as a trait and rendered by a custom persona template. Its survey-memory facilities can also reproduce the sequential accumulation of prior responses. The statement that EDSL “reduces to” short-attribute prompting therefore mistakes one default presentation for a capability limitation. The narrower and supportable contrast is that Anamnesis packages narrative generation, demographic inference and matching, and survey execution into a specialized graphical workflow.

References

- [1] S.-Z. Yu, J. Suh, S. Chang, and D. M. Chan. *Anamnesis: An Open-Source Platform for Large-Scale Backstory-Conditioned Survey Simulation*. arXiv:2607.10628v1, 2026. <https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.10628>.
- [2] Expected Parrot. *EDSL: Tools for AI-powered surveys and experiments*. Open-source software, MIT License. <https://github.com/expectedparrot/eds1>.